naval and commercial power like Britain. Lambton told Arthur Wellesley his plan, who in turn spoke to his brother the Governor General. Lambton got the job.

The first thing that Lambton did was to order a state-of-the-art theodolite to help with the survey. A theodolite is basically a telescope that has been specially adapted to allow the very accurate measurement of angles needed for triangulation. The equipment Lambton ordered weighed half a ton and had to be shipped from England. On the way it was captured by the French and taken to Mauritius. However, when the French realized that it was a scientific instrument, they gallantly repacked and sent it to Madras. At last, Lambton could start on his work.

Lambton began by establishing a baseline at sea-level in 1802. He did this just south of Chennai's famous Marina beach. From a flagpole on the beach, he ascertained the horizontal distance to the grandstand of Madras racecourse. Once he had established this base-line, Lambton set in motion a sequence of triangulation that would crisscross India for the next sixty years, consuming not just his life but that of his successor George Everest. In 1802, the East India Company had expected the work to have finished in five years! It is a testimony to the prestige and usefulness of this project that it was not stopped for six decades, despite the time and resources it would ultimately consume.

Trudging through jungles, mountains, farmlands and villages with a heavy theodolite in tow must have been very difficult work. Often there were bandits, hostile local populations, and suspicious kingdoms that were still not reconciled to British rule. Many a time there were long delays because dust and haze obscured visibility. At each location, the theodolite had to be dragged up to a height in order to provide a reading. Tall buildings were used where there were no hills. In 1808, Lambton decided to use the massive eleventh-century Brihadishwara temple in Thanjavur. The temple dedicated to Lord Shiva had been built by the Cholas at the height of their power and is a huge structure even by modern standards. Unfortunately, the ropes slipped and the theodolite was smashed. For all its size, it was a delicate and minutely calibrated instrument. A lesser man would have given